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Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1934-1937; 1971

Coverage Date: 1930-1971

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S): 6 Totem And Taboo

30 The extreme case is that of Namoos first-borns who are in daily contact with domestic fowl and are constantly required to exercise abstinence from eating it. The same is true of other domestic animals that are totems, e.g., the cat or the dog, and of such wild creatures as pythons, crocodiles, monitor lizards, etc.

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31. To the best of my knowledge species of trees or grasses do not figure among Tallensi totemistic objects. But trees are often ancestor shrines and some grasses are tabooed in certain circumstances.

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32 I have often been present at Talis domestic sacrifices where a Namoo sister's son who is known to be a first-born is either not offered the portion of a sacrificed chicken due to his kinship status or else politely declines it if his hosts do not know that he is a *mokyihib* – one who taboos the fowl. It used to remind me of the behaviour of vegetarians and teetotalers among my friends at home.

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33 Cf. Lienhardt, 1961: 151, Dinka form individual 'respect' relationships with 'emblems' of animals, etc., which have affected them.

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34 As both Evans-Pritchard and Lienhardt (1961: 108–18) explain. Since insects, tree and grass species, artifacts, parts of animals and a variety of

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other objects serve as 'emblems' of Dinka and to some extent Nuer clan-divinities, both Evans-Pritchard and Lienhardt specially emphasize the absence of any ascertainable principle, utilitarian or otherwise, by which these totemistic objects are selected.

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35 Cf. Lienhardt, *op. cit.* p. 155, '... the Dinka themselves often think of them [i.e. the clan-divinities] as acquired by chance — a chance association ... between the founding ancestor of a clan and the species....'

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36 For example the Hill Talis clans that taboo tortoise (*pakur*) and water tortoise (*mieng*) regard them as being akin, that is, as respectively the terrestrial and the aquatic representatives of the same animal kind. The tree lizard (*uuk*), monitor lizard (*woo*), and crocodile (*bang*) are similarly regarded as being related kinds, though there is no notion of their being of common descent. All of these are regarded as 'earth animals'. These associations are obviously governed by perceptual and logical connections laid down in Tallensi beliefs and lore. The plural clandivinities of Dinka clans are clustered together by similar culturally defined associations. Cf. also the ingenious oppositions utilized by the Bemba in coupling together complementary or antagonistic 'joking' clans. (See Richards, A. I., 1937.)

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37 Where artifacts as well as animal species are amongst the totemic objects the relevance of perceived or imputed differences is even less. This is much plainer among the Nuer and Dinka whose totem objects comprise so miscellaneous an assemblage as to rule out entirely any possibility of arranging them by criteria of inter-specific differences.

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38 The Tallensi have a considerable vocabulary for distinguishing living creatures, humans, persons, animals, things and supernaturals.

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39 The Dinka go even further. Lienhardt says of the clan-divinities to whom they address prayers and sacrifices — they are 'the very type of  313 agnatic ancestor; the emblems are the very type of clansmen'. They 'have the status of clansmen when regarded as individual creatures, and as fathers and ancestors when regarded as representatives of the species and thus of divinity itself.' Cf. Lienhardt, 1961: 132, 135. It is of course, not a peculiarity of Africa cultures or of primitive cultures in general to attribute human characteristics to animals. We do this all the time with household pets, horses and dogs. (Cf. Lévi-Strauss' ingenious comparisons between the names popularly given to animals and plants and human proper names, 1962*b*: 266–86). Children identify with their pet rabbits, hamsters, dogs and cats, quite as if they were siblings and can be plunged into profound grief if they die. Adults, especially old people, also identify with their pets and often treat them like children. The story of Androcles and his lion reminds us that a brotherly relationship with a wild beast is conceivable too. Best of all are the delightful

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legends of what Helen Waddell calls 'the mutual charities between Saints and beasts' which she has so beautifully translated (Waddell 1934). These legends tell of the mutual beneficence and trust of a variety of wild animals and the hermit saints of the desert. None of those tales, redolent as they are of piety and faith, would astonish Tallensi. Indeed some of them match their own totemic myths. For instance, there is the story of St Puchome who, whenever he had to cross the river was carried over by the crocodiles 'with the utmost subservience'. And, most famous of all, is the story of St Jerome, the lion and the donkey (1934: 30–8). The lion limps into the monastery and offers his injured paw to the Saint, who extracts the thorn. 'And now, all wildness and savagery laid aside, the lion began to go to and fro among them as peaceable and domestic as any animal about the house.' He is put to work to guard the donkey out in the pasture. One day he negligently falls asleep. The donkey is stolen. 'Conscious of guilt,' the tale continues, 'he no longer dared walk in.' After further humiliations a chance encounter – interpreted as a miracle by the pious fathers – enables the lion to retrieve his lapse and all ends happily. This is one of many such stories in which animals are depicted as moral beings symbiotically incorporated in the Saints' world of human and divine relationships. Appropriately enough, as I write this, a news item relating to a familiar sight in the neighbourhood of my own work-place, shows how totemistic identifications of animals with men survive even in sophisticated academic circles and I quote it verbatim from the *Times* of 30 April 1966:

Dr Peter Kapitza, the Russian physicist, walked into the Cavendish Laboratory at Cambridge today for the first time in 32 years.

He looked at a helium liquidiser which he designed in 1932 and is now a museum piece in the laboratory, and with emotion he said: 'This all brings back a lot of memories. It feels very funny to be back again.'

Dr Kapitza, now 71, is director of the Institute of Physical Problems ■ 314 of the Academy of Sciences in Russia. He was assistant director of magnetic research at the Cavendish from 1924 to 1932, and was a member of Lord Rutherford's team of scientists.

Outside the Mond Laboratory, Dr Kapitza gazed up at a carving of a crocodile on the wall, and put an end to years of rumours in Cambridge as to the origin of the crocodile. He said: 'It was my idea that the crocodile should be incorporated in the building to represent Lord Rutherford. In Russia the crocodile represents the father of the family'.

The identification of crocodile with father-figures would strike a Tallensi as perfectly natural and would have gladdened the heart of Freud.

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